regulations, coordinating monetary and other economic policies, securing financial flows, and facilitating lending. The traditional bases for the international economic order were the Bretton Woods institutions: the International Monetary Fund (IMF), World Bank and General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT) which evolved into the World Trade Organization (WTO). In recent years, the IMF and World Bank have been criticized for their dominance by Europe and the United States. For a time, India sought to work with other partners, including in the BRICS, to create alternate mechanisms. But after those institutions reached their own limitations, India sought to work more within existing structures to widen their mandate and improve their efficiency. Meanwhile, coordinating monetary policy after the global financial crisis of 2008–09 saw the elevation of the G-20 (along with the Basel III accord on banking supervision) as vehicles to manage international economic and financial matters.

Other important international agreements concern standards, which extend to such issues as telecommunications and air traffic control. To give but one example now often taken for granted, the International Organization for Standards (ISO)—a non-governmental entity that has been granted consultative status by the United Nations—created a global standard for shipping containers in 1968, known as ISO 668. This ensured that standard-sized containers could travel around the world via ship, train, or truck without being opened, thus bringing down the costs and inefficiencies of international commerce. Such containers now account for over 60 per cent of all sea-borne trade. [5]

The WTO, meanwhile, ran into its own problems during the so-called Doha Round of negotiations. Among other problems, India felt that its priorities, shared by some other developing countries, were often side lined—such as on food security. It thus sometimes wielded a veto on issues such as trade facilitation. But in recent years, broader questions about the further reduction of global trade barriers and setbacks to the WTO’s arbitration mechanism have called the institution’s effectiveness into question. Instead, trade and economic facilitation has assumed new forms, including bilateral